

ASUS Zenfone 3

Not a complete package

When you jack up a phone's price, you have much more to live up to. ASUS chose a tough road this time, possibly to change user perception and be recognised as a premium brand. However, the Zenfone 3 doesn't quite hit the right notes, the way the Zenfone 2 did. To be clear, it does have redeeming values, but it's not the no brainer its predecessor was.

The Snapdragon 625 is an octa-core SoC built on the 14nm process. This makes it quite efficient in terms of battery life and heat, but at the expense of raw power. The eight Cortex A53 cores together are weaker than a Snapdragon 652 or even the 650. Of course, ASUS' bloated and heavy ZenUI affects the performance too.

The Zenfone 3's performance is 80% lower than the OnePlus 3 on graphics, and about 60% on single core CPU speed. It's quite close in terms of multi-core performance, though. As a result, there are visible lags in games like Injustice and Asphalt, and load times are also high. It works for basic users, but power users and mobile gamers won't enjoy the phone.

The good news is that it takes some doing to get this phone up to 40 degrees Celsius, and it's also good battery-wise. The Zenfone 3 runs for over 11 hours on the Geekbench 3 battery test, with a score of two 7043. On a regular day, you'll easily get the full 24 hours with this phone. We got an average screen on time of 4 hours, which is quite good, especially at 60-70% brightness.

Speaking of brightness, prepare for a somewhat dim display. The Zenfone 3 can go up to 618 Lux, nearly 200 Lux lower than a OnePlus 3. Also, the contrast ratio isn't very high and the display lacks deep blacks. Overall, the Zenfone 3's display isn't something special, but just about does the job.

The best feature of this phone, though, is its camera. It 16MP rear camera takes natural photos, with emphasis on true to life colours,



Price
₹27,999

rather than vibrant and over-saturated images. There is some noise in photos, but not enough to hamper social sharing needs. Sharpness and contrast are appreciable, but not stunning.

Under low light, the Zenfone 3's "optimisation" mode produces bright photos, even in extremely low light. They're soft, and lacks details, but it's still much better than the OnePlus 3 and others in this range. However, without this mode, you get the same as any other phone.

The camera actually makes the cheaper (3GB RAM) variant of the Zenfone 3 a better buy than the Xiaomi Mi 5 and the Vivo V3 Max, since its camera is vastly better and makes up for the performance gap.

Last but not the least, the Zenfone 3's design is reminiscent of last year's Galaxy S6. It doesn't feel as premium though, and we'd easily pick a OnePlus 3 over this one.

From a build point of view, the Zenfone 3's machined speaker holes lack the premium finish, and you can see slight (very slight) gaps where the plastic antenna bands pass its metal frame. This is also not a phone you'd want to drop. With Gorilla Glass 3 on both sides, there's too much to break.

Further, if you care about ergonomics, you will find this tough to deal with. Thick front bezels and a 5.5 inch display make it wide. This makes it tough to get a good grip, especially because of the slippery glass back. The thin fingerprint sensor on the back is also tough to reach.

To sum up, the OnePlus 3 is a better choice at ₹27,999, however, you may still consider the cheaper variant of the Zenfone 3. This isn't the best phone ASUS has made since the Zenfone 5, but it does have some good elements.

It has a good camera, but that's pretty much the only thing making it worth consideration. It's not a phone for the power users and needs a more refined design to really stand a chance.

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Specifications

Display Size: 5.5-inch;
Resolution: 1080x1920;
SoC: Snapdragon 625; **Processor:** 2GHz octa-core; **RAM:** 4GB;
Internal Storage: 64GB;
Expandable upto: 128GB;
Rear Camera: 16MP;
Front Camera: 8MP;
Battery: 3000mAh; **Wi-Fi standards:** 802.11 a/ b/ g/ n/ ac

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